also inaugurated. For Japan, India has emerged as among its most important security partners in the Indo–Pacific after the United States and Australia. [40]

For all the positive momentum, India–Japan relations will continue to have some obvious limitations. These include resource constraints in India and a still largely pacifist public opinion in Japan. Relations have often required top-down involvement, rather than an evolving into an organic partnership buttressed by business and societal connections. There are also structural constraints that will have to be worked around, including India's presence outside US alliance structures. This complicates some operational cooperation, including military communications and information sharing. Defence trade and technological cooperation has also not progressed, in part because of Japan's lack of experience with foreign sales and also due to questions of export controls and the management of classified information. Nonetheless, despite these evident limitations and concerns, the broader trajectory of India–Japan strategic relations has recently been positive. [41]

A third country that contributes significantly to the regional balance is Australia. India–Australia relations had previously been marked by differences, including on Pakistan, the Indian Ocean, China, and India's nuclear status. Some of that has been put to rest, including through a lifting of Australia's uranium ban on India and cooperation in forums such as IORA. Nonetheless, after several years of cautious engagement, India–Australia defence relations significantly increased after 2019 and in some areas surpassed India's relations with Japan. Military exercises, particularly by the navies, became more regular and complex. India also took part in Australia's Pitch Black air exercises, and they have engaged in official or semi-official trilateral dialogues involving Japan, Indonesia, and France. The two countries also established a 2+2 dialogue involving the foreign and defence ministers. [42]

The coming together of India, the United States, Japan, and Australia—or the Quad—was a natural progression of the strengthening bilateral relationships. The four countries initially coordinated in an ad hoc manner during relief operations following the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami. In 2007, they held a one-off quadrilateral Malabar naval exercise, along with